

Zaira Christa Barakat

BRAND DEVELOPMENT · CREATIVE STRATEGY · CULTURAL STRATEGY

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PROFILE

Brand and cultural strategist in the making, translating cultural research into brand strategy, creative direction, and content across fashion, hospitality, and cultural events.

Tripled ticket sales year-on-year as Co-Creative Director of Oxford's largest student fashion event, and spent six years supporting content production and photoshoots for a hospitality brand — combining hands-on creative execution with an Oxford research background and an MA in Cultural and Creative Industries at King's College London.

Currently writing The Archives by Zai, a weekly essay project applying cultural and academic theory to fashion, nightlife, and brand culture, as a public, ongoing record of research-led strategic thinking.

EDUCATION

King's College London

2025 — 2026

MA Cultural and Creative Industries

University of Oxford, Somerville College

2022 — 2025

BA (Hons) Music, 2:1

EXPERIENCE — CREATIVE & BRAND STRATEGY

Zaira Christa Fashion Label

London · 2022 — Present

Founder & Creative Director

- Built an independent fashion label from concept to catwalk, delivering two full seasonal collections and runway presentations by independently directing creative concept, garment production, styling, and casting.
- Established the label's brand identity and digital presence, producing original campaign photography and editorial content that articulates a distinct creative point of view across every collection.

Oxford Fashion Gala

Oxford · 2023 – 2025

Co-Creative Director & Co-Marketing Director

- Led end-to-end creative direction for Oxford's largest annual fashion event, producing a thematically unified show by directing concept development, casting, set design, and choreography from brief to live performance.
- Tripled ticket sales year-on-year (a 200% increase) by designing and executing a multi-platform social campaign combining curated content, strategic collaborations, and a data-informed posting schedule.
- Delivered a cohesive campaign identity across all audience-facing assets, copy, and promotional content, coordinating a volunteer team to execute the Gala's creative vision at scale.

Mandaloun Westfield

London · 2019 – 2025

Social Media & Content Assistant

- Supported Mandaloun's social media content across Instagram and Facebook for six years, executing planned campaigns and day-to-day posts under the brand's marketing direction.
- Assisted on photoshoots and seasonal campaign productions, helping coordinate shoots, prepare assets, and maintain visual consistency across platform-specific content.
- Built six years of hands-on experience translating brand direction into finished content, developing a practical grounding in visual storytelling and platform-specific production.

ADDITIONAL EXPERIENCE

Levi Strauss

London · 2025

Stylist

- Exceeded sales targets during Black Friday, one of retail's highest-pressure trading periods, by delivering personalised styling consultations that lifted units per transaction (UPT) above the team benchmark.

The Reach Brasserie

London · 2025 – 2026

Bar Manager

- Managed day-to-day operations in a high-footfall venue and designed a curated seasonal cocktail programme, balancing consistent brand standards, supplier relationships, and staff performance with cost efficiency and commercial viability.

PROJECTS

Independent Research & Essay Practice

- Writing and publishing weekly essays applying cultural and academic theory to fashion, nightlife, and brand culture, building a public, research-led body of work as ongoing proof of strategic and cultural thinking.

SKILLS & COMPETENCIES

Cultural & Strategic Research

Cultural capital analysis, subcultural and trend research, brand positioning, audience insight, theory-to-strategy translation.

Creative Direction & Strategy

Art direction, visual storytelling, brand identity, campaign development, content planning, photoshoot production, Adobe Photoshop, Illustrator, InDesign, Premiere Pro.

Leadership & Operations

Team leadership, project management, cross-functional collaboration, client communication, budget awareness.

Languages

English (fluent), French (advanced), Arabic — Lebanese dialect (intermediate).